



MONTHLY UPDATE

Nigeria: monthly update, July 2026

Edition of 2026-08-17 · 107 systems and instruments tracked, 8 of them not held

Developments recorded from artefacts published between 2026-07-01 and 2026-08-17 – July 2026 carried forward to the date of issue, so the report holds the nightly catch to the day it was cut. Sections follow the status report.

Summary of the month

Across a single fortnight the identity commission converted the NIMC Act 2026 into bilateral operating agreements with the electoral commission, defence, solid minerals, trade, youth, women's affairs and the development bank; took over the national public key infrastructure as root certification authority; completed ICAO directory integration, making the passport cryptographically verifiable; and saw its number extended to airport boarding and farmer verification. No account of any of it states a lawful basis, consent mechanism or audit trail for the sharing involved.

The exchange went live on 30 July: a single sign-on Government Service Portal integrated with the national data exchange so agencies stop re-collecting citizen data.

In the courts, the data-protection regulator won its registration authority in the Federal High Court, a private claimant won damages without needing the regulator at all, and the digital-lending regulations that had been suspended since April were upheld and re-enforced.

Infrastructure

Connectivity

An account published on 29 July puts about [101,000 km of fibre already built](#) and finds that it bypasses some 130m Nigerians — a utilisation and last-mile finding sitting directly against the 90,000 km headline of the national fibre programme.

What is built is being cut faster than it is being protected. The regulator [put fibre-optic cable cuts from road works at more than 5,000 in the first half of 2026](#) and [stood up a standing committee with the works and communications ministries and the National Security Adviser's office](#) to coordinate protection of fibre designated as critical national information infrastructure. No terms of reference, meeting cycle, budget or enforcement power is published for it.

The backbone programme meanwhile looked outward before it broke ground. Nigerian and Burkinabè digital ministries [met in Ouagadougou on 12 August to explore connecting the planned 90,000 km open-access backbone into Burkina Faso](#), with a [stated aim of halving internet costs through it](#). Nothing was signed, and physical deployment still stands at 2027 on the project documents.

On the tower estate, shareholders of the tower company [approved the acquirer's cash buyout of the 75.3% it does not already own](#), the target's first-half revenue rising 8.2% to US\$844m while rising Nigerian diesel costs and acquisition charges cut operating income 38%. Federal strategic review of the transaction is the last position the base holds on the state's side.

Data Storage

A Lagos cloud region [entered service on 10 August](#), the third on its operator's platform alongside Lisbon and Johannesburg and presented around data residency since the Nigeria Data Protection Act took effect — three legal jurisdictions carried on one platform. It joins [about 26 facilities carrying 50 to 56 MW live against some 124 MW installed](#), Africa's second-largest market after South Africa at about 15% of continental capacity, most of it in Lagos.

Cybersecurity

The communications regulator [issued a Guidance Note on cybersecurity budgets on 7 August](#) under a framework effective since 23 February, adding a dedicated budget line with tracked spend and periodic audit, requiring a Chief Information Security Officer, and restating two-year in-country retention of call logs and traffic data; the compliance clock ends 23 February 2027. Two further bodies are announced and no more: [a Ministerial Advisory Council on Cybersecurity](#) with no membership or terms of reference published, and [a Payment Security Operations Centre](#) set as a 2028 target with no legal basis, funding line or operator named.

Data Exchange

The telecoms and electrification regulators signed a [data-sharing agreement](#) on 30 July overlaying electrification geodata with universal-service deployment data.

Standards

The technology agency approved a [software quality assurance framework](#) on 30 July making independent third-party testing a mandatory condition of IT project clearance — full operation is set for Q2 2027 and no licensed testing organisation is yet on file.

Rural digital data capture

The communications minister told the President on 4 August that [deployment of about 3,700 towers begins around October](#), reaching more than 20 million people in communities with no telecoms service and with the capital stated as raised — no funding source, operator or contract is named. The baseline against which it is measured is [23% of rural communities connected to 57% urban](#).

New investments

A Lagos fibre operator closed the [₦4.05bn first tranche](#) of a ₦20bn programme in the domestic bond market on 27 July. It is long-dated local capital in a market whose rates push savings to short maturities.

Digital public infrastructure

Technical Capacity

The identity authority's servers, databases and networks are not sized for compulsory use of the national identification number across the fourteen sectors the amended Act reaches — a compulsory register carrying a 2027 election-integrity risk if it cannot be relied on across that volume.

Data Exchange

Nine agencies took bilateral cover under the amended identity Act inside a fortnight, among them [Solid Minerals](#), the [Presidency](#) and [Women Affairs and the Bank of Industry](#); no account states a lawful basis, consent mechanism or retention rule for the sharing that follows. The [Nigeria Data Exchange now moves personal data between ministries in production](#) behind the Government Service Portal, on the same silence. Against the single-source-of-truth framing, named practitioners [describe the arrangement as federated linkage on a shared identifier](#), with banks still reconciling by hand. The [National Single Window](#), launched in March, is contested by licensed customs agents who say clearance paperwork has multiplied rather than consolidated.

Digital Identity and CRVS

Identity gained infrastructure and kept its gap. The passport became [cryptographically verifiable at 111 member states' borders](#) on 16 July; the identity authority [took the national root certification authority over from NITDA](#) on 21 July; and [V-Pass went live](#) for airport security checks and boarding on the number and face biometrics. Registration stands at [136 million against a target of 180 million by 31 December](#), leaving about 100 million people uncaptured on the information minister's own figure. The root certification authority it took over also created a conflict: the NIMC Act 2026 makes the identity commission the root authority while the [still-pending Digital Economy and E-Governance Bill carries its own electronic-signature provisions](#), and which instrument governs digital signatures is unresolved.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Payments produced real-time reporting of every licensed bureau's FX purchases from 15 July.

On 2 August an account of African corporate venture capital recorded that [tier-one Nigerian banks hold payments infrastructure inside the group rather than at arm's length](#), and that the central bank has begun regulating fintech ownership as well as conduct. The base carries no earlier statement of the ownership position, so no change can be stated.

The central bank then set out what it wants that infrastructure to look like. A circular [imposes market-structure caps of 25% on card issuing and 15% on acquiring, mandatory localisation of payment data by 1 January 2027, and disclosure of ultimate beneficial owners](#) on banks, fintechs and payment service providers, against an estimated [US\\$850m a year spent on offshore hosting and about 90% of Nigerian payment data currently held abroad](#). Those figures are the analysing firm's estimates and the circular text itself is not held.

Three admission gates opened alongside it. The central bank [opened a second sandbox cohort to virtual-asset and data-enabled firms, applications running 12 to 31 August](#), and chairs a new Virtual Asset Council with the securities regulator and the revenue service, against an estimated US\$92.1bn transacted in cryptocurrency by Nigerians between July 2024 and June 2025; the securities regulator [admitted two further firms to its incubation programme, taking it to 12 since July](#). Neither publishes a graduation route or licensing outcome. The regulated naira stablecoin [went live on a public blockchain on 12 August](#), with no supply, holder count or reserve attestation published.

Taxation moved in the other direction. Peer-to-peer and over-the-counter traders [warned on 14 August that the 1.5% virtual-asset stamp duty and the taxes beside it could push activity into unregulated channels](#), the rules having been signed on 31 July. Separately the Lagos State revenue service is [testing whether creator-economy platform payouts are royalties subject to 5% withholding tax, pressing two named platforms to deduct at source](#) under the 2025 tax act — the same authority's earlier attempt to make a ride-hailing platform a collection agent being the precedent. No assessment, ruling or judgment is published in either matter.

Registries (population, land, address, etc.)

[Civil registration](#) went nationwide from 1 July on a platform run as a public-private partnership, a private contractor carrying availability and security duties over the register of births and deaths.

Sectoral management information systems (HMIS, EMIS, etc.)

Federal [HR and payroll](#) moved to a locally built platform across more than 508 ministries and more than 600,000 civil servants, justified explicitly as data sovereignty.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The [Government Service Portal](#) was soft-launched on 30 July as a single sign-on gateway built with Korean financing, piloted since 2025. Behind the login it integrates with the national data exchange so agencies share citizen data rather than each re-collecting it. The lawful basis and the audit arrangements are unstated, and no published rule answers either.

Legislation and regulation

On 20 July the digital consumer-lending regulations suspended since April were upheld, with [enforcement resuming](#) on 22 July. The court agreed with the challengers that a consumer-protection mandate does not extend to licensing telecommunications operators, and no joint framework for co-supervision is published.

An [executive order on virtual assets](#) created a council and office over existing mandates without transferring powers, and a tax circular dated 31 July collected a [1.5% stamp duty withheld in the asset itself](#) and remitted in the originating token, so the federal government now holds Bitcoin and USDT receipts.

Strategies, plans and policies

The central bank published [Payments System Vision 2028](#) on 17 June, a three-year horizon replacing a five-year one, from 2025 baselines of ₦1.2 quadrillion in electronic transactions and 69.5 million unique bank verification numbers. [Its 2028 targets are 95% financial inclusion, five million QR merchant outlets and a 70% reduction in fraud losses](#), and the 132-page text carries a stablecoin issuer-licensing regime no secondary account reported.

Regional collaboration

[Nigeria, Kenya and Morocco are the first pilots](#) for shared cross-border rails for identity, payments and trusted data exchange, and [the country implementation forum was inaugurated in Abuja on 29 July](#).

ICT Industry

Mobile money revenue at the largest operator grew about 132% in the first half and active wallets rose 1.3 million to [five million](#), while suspending a single airtime-lending product took second-quarter fintech revenue to ₦12.99bn, down 72.4% year on year — establishing that the book the market had read as a payments business was substantially an airtime-lending business.

Training and skills

A [diaspora health-workforce registry](#) is described as newly launched, with no launch date, custodian agency, enrolment terms or data-protection basis stated in anything held — a register standing up ahead of its governance.

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Enugu [opened free digital storefronts, company-registration support, digital-trade training and payment enablement to 1,000 state businesses](#) with Afreximbank's trade platform; cost, funder and selection method are unstated.

National statistics

An inclusive-data initiative brought the national statistics office into a five-country programme.

New investments

[Domestic retail investors traded ₦2.86tn of equities between January and May, up 138.76% year on year and 36.22% of activity, against ₦4.06tn institutional](#). [Participants name the registrar layer as the operational failure that matters](#): shareholder names are recorded inconsistently, and dividend payment is delayed behind it.

Governance and regulation

Legislation and regulation

On 29 July a claimant won the [first damages award](#) under the Act — ₦15m, ₦500,000 costs and 10% post-judgment interest — against a bank that kept marketing after consent was withdrawn. Liability rested on three instruments at once. The court also held that personal data must be erased on termination but refused wholesale deletion where statutory banking and anti-money-laundering retention applies.

Strategies, plans and policies

An [Artificial Intelligence and Cyber Diplomacy Unit](#) sits inside the foreign ministry, coordinating engagement on emerging technologies, established after the 2025 inaugural seminar.

Regional collaboration

Ministers adopted an Abuja declaration on meaningful connectivity.

Data protection

On 28–29 July the Federal High Court [upheld the data-protection commission's power](#) to designate and register controllers and processors of major importance, dismissing a suit that had sought to place PoS agents outside the class; the commission immediately directed every unregistered entity to register. The judgment is not held and its delivery date is unestablished. The commission then used the power: on 13 August it [opened a forensic investigation into a federal university, a bank and a technology vendor over the alleged use of students' personal data to open bank accounts without consent](#). No finding or penalty has followed.

Artificial intelligence and the technology sector

Access to services

An [agent-network microfinance operator founded in 2018 was profiled during the month](#), reaching microenterprises and the historically unbanked through trained local agents with naira-denominated formalisation and credit rather than dollar substitution; no user, loan-book or coverage figures are published.

AI

Nothing moved on the national AI policy, the risk-based regime inside the digital-economy bill, or the surveillance estate.

The activity was at the state level and abroad. Anambra State [set out a Vision 2030 push on artificial intelligence and paperless government that its own ICT agency says is constrained by weak connectivity and computing capacity](#), with no budget, procurement, delivery date or named system published. The federal IT agency [signed two memoranda in Toronto with Canadian firms on financial inclusion, local AI infrastructure, technology transfer and digital skills](#), and separately [pushed a National Sovereign Cloud initiative against a stated position in which over 85% of workloads run on public cloud largely hosted abroad](#). None of the three carries a value, a timetable or a delivery commitment.

ICT Industry

Two of five commercial developments this month, neither regulatory: an enterprise arm distributing a spreadsheet-analysis agent through universities and co-working spaces, and a venture-financed skilling company.

Innovation ecosystem

A [drive-to-own vehicle financier raised US\\$250m at a US\\$2.1bn valuation on 5 August](#), financing a 42,000-vehicle fleet across fourteen countries against platform earnings — making ride-hailing income the credit-scoring and repayment rail for drivers outside formal banking, a class of alternative-data underwriting no Nigerian instrument addresses. The communications regulator [leased its Digital Industrial Park and Learning Centre to Enugu State for fifteen years](#), its executive vice chairman saying that buildings alone do not create innovation; no rent, investment commitment or performance condition is stated. A [crowdsourced food-price platform reports about 2,500 users](#).

Training and skills

On 3 August a private university announced [robotics, drone and virtual-reality teaching laboratories](#) to be built by a defence-technology firm that holds a joint venture with the state arms corporation. Lab count, cost, funding source, intake, research ownership and dual-use vetting are all unstated.

Rural digital data capture

[Talks on artificial intelligence for smallholder farmers are exploratory](#): no programme, funding, timeline or counterparty ministry is named.

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Cross River's executive council [approved phase one of a facial- and plate-recognition network](#) specified with Huawei and implemented through its local partner, covering Calabar intersections and government precincts, coastal communities and waterways, the Ikang Expressway and Carnival routes, against a stated baseline of under 10% analogue coverage of the metropolis and nothing in five other named towns. The [claimed gains are emergency response falling from over 45 minutes to under twelve and 120 technician jobs](#); no lawful basis, retention rule or oversight arrangement for the face and plate data appears anywhere in the announcement.

New investments

A [credit-scoring business](#) scores people without bank accounts from their payment patterns and sells the output to banks, treating everyday transactional behaviour as the credit file — which extends access to people without bank accounts and makes payment data an underwriting input. Consent, purpose limitation and whether an automated refusal can be contested are not addressed in anything held.

Inclusion and capacity

Digital divides

A global memory-chip shortage was reported on 29 July as turning device cost into a divide variable in a market that imports nearly every computer it sells.

Nothing moved on the identity gender gap, on rural access, or on the schools programme whose January 2026 completion date passed undelivered.

Access to services

A [digital self-care platform went live for University of Lagos students](#), routing to free contraceptives through the state health ministry and UNFPA supply chain, with expansion to other Lagos campuses planned.

Training and skills

Seventy teachers from 40 Lagos public schools were trained in AI literacy.

On 4 August the [fourth Mastercard Foundation EdTech Fellowship cohort](#) was selected: 12 startups, taking the programme to 72 companies supported since 2019, each offered up to US\$100,000 in equity-free funding over 18 months with Co-creation HUB. The intake is allocated against named categories rather than an open call.

Finance

New investments

A [US\\$110m debt facility](#) for technology startups opened for applications on 30 July.

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